



“The key of India is London.”

BENJAMIN DISRAELI, ADDRESSING THE HOUSE OF LORDS, MARCH 1881

impose tariffs or subsidies on imports and exports. Instead, they invested in the country's infrastructure, especially trains, which assisted economic development, and irrigation works. On the tea estates that proliferated from the 1850s, indentured labor was widely employed. Most Indians lived in abject poverty, a state not helped by severe famines in the second half of the 19th century. Conditions for migrants were miserable and mortality rates high. Their plight, and the continued deployment of Indian troops on imperial service in other countries, stirred nationalist feelings, resulting in an awakening Indian political consciousness.

INDENTURED LABOR A type of labor that binds apprentice to master. The employer offers little pay, but provides food and lodgings.

In December 1885, the Indian National Congress, or Congress Party, met for the first time in Bombay (now Mumbai). As the main nationalist political party, it was initially moderate and widely representative. By the beginning of the 20th century, however, a younger, more politically militant generation of Indians emerged, calling for independence from British rule (see pp.408–11).

AFTER

The flash point was reached in 1857, in Meerut, northern India, when rumor spread that the British had introduced a new rifle and cartridge into the Indian Army. The cartridges, which soldiers had to bite open, were lubricated with a grease containing pig and cow fat, offending both Hindu and Muslim soldiers. The revolt spread across the country, and was finally quelled in 1859 after much bloodshed. In 1858 a royal decree stated that all EIC rights were to be handed over to the British Crown. Victoria assumed the role of Queen of India and Britain. The reign of the EIC was over, and the British Raj had begun.



Christian miniature
Indian artists often painted Christian subjects in order to appeal to the increasing Christian population of the country and patrons of the British Raj.

Rule Britannia

Initially, after the Indian Mutiny and the decline of the EIC, many policies remained unchanged, yet British attitudes toward Indians shifted from openness to insularity. As more British families arrived with their servants, private clubs were set up that became symbols of wealth and snobbery. Facilitated by new railroads, exports such as cotton, wheat, and tea enriched the British, yet profits rarely reached native pockets. Despite the fledgling nature of

industries such as textiles, and their potential for collapse, the British insisted on an economic policy of *laissez-faire*, or free trade, refusing to

In the 20th century, demands for Indian independence grew. Indian sovereignty was accompanied by the division of the country.

THE FREEDOM STRUGGLE

At the end of the 19th century, calls for Indian independence were growing. In 1905, Lord Curzon **partitioned Bengal**, dividing it into two states. This led to a nationwide protest.

RELIGIOUS DIVIDE

Bengal's population was mainly **Hindu in the west** and **Muslim in the east**. Partition was reversed in 1911 after great political unrest.

PARTITION OF INDIA

The move for **Indian independence** was galvanized by the arrival of **Mahatma Gandhi** **408–09** ». Committed to ridding his native land

of foreign rule, his charismatic personality helped to unite the country in the struggle. After arduous constitutional negotiations, the British agreed to transfer power on **August 15, 1947**. As they

left India, the **largest mass migration in history** took place. Freedom led to partitioning, with the creation of the independent nations of **the Dominion of Pakistan and the Union of India** **410–11** ».



FLAG OF PAKISTAN

SRI LANKA

Sri Lanka (**Ceylon** before 1972) lies 19 miles (31 km) off the coast of India. Parts of Sri Lanka were colonized by the Portuguese and Dutch in the 16th and 17th centuries. The whole country was **ceded to the British Empire in 1815**. A nationalist movement arose in the early 20th century and independence was granted in 1948.